

29 Moses

The reluctant shepherd who led Israel out of Egypt and spoke with God face to face.

Moses was born a Hebrew slave under a death sentence, raised in Pharaoh's household, and trained as a shepherd in the desert. At eighty he met God in a burning bush and was sent to say, "Let my people go." Through him God brought Israel out of slavery, gave the Law at Sinai, and built a nation in the wilderness. He was prophet, lawgiver and intercessor, yet also a man who argued, lost his temper, and was kept out of the Promised Land. The New Testament names him more than any other Old Testament person.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hebrew <i>Moshe</i> , linked to "drew out" (Exodus 2:10)
<i>Family</i>	Son of Amram and Jochebed; brother of Aaron and Miriam
<i>Wife and sons</i>	Zipporah; Gershom and Eliezer (Exodus 2:21–22; 18:2–4)
<i>Lifespan</i>	120 years: 40 in Egypt, 40 in Midian, 40 in the wilderness
<i>Key places</i>	Egypt, Midian, Sinai (Horeb), Kadesh, Moab, Mount Nebo
<i>Key people</i>	Pharaoh of the Exodus, Aaron, Miriam, Jethro, Joshua, Caleb
<i>New Testament</i>	Named about 80 times, more than any other Old Testament figure

*"And there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses,
whom the LORD knew face to face,"*

Deuteronomy 34:10, KJV

The life of Moses

Dates are approximate (BC), following the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC (1 Kings 6:1). Many scholars prefer c. 1260 BC, about 185 years later.

c. 1526 BC <i>Birth</i>	● Hidden and drawn out Hidden from Pharaoh's decree in a basket among the reeds, he is found and raised by Pharaoh's daughter. <i>Exodus 1:22-2:10</i>
c. 1486 BC <i>Age 40</i>	● Flees to Midian He kills an Egyptian who was beating a Hebrew, and flees when Pharaoh seeks his life. <i>Exodus 2:11-15; Acts 7:23-29</i>
c. 1486-1446 BC <i>Age 40 to 80</i>	● Shepherd in Midian He marries Zipporah and keeps Jethro's flock in the desert for forty years. <i>Exodus 2:16-22; 3:1; Acts 7:29-30</i>
c. 1446 BC <i>Age 80</i>	● The burning bush At Horeb God reveals his name, "I AM THAT I AM," and sends a reluctant Moses to Egypt. <i>Exodus 3:1-4:17; 7:7</i>
c. 1446 BC <i>Age 80</i>	● Out of Egypt Ten plagues fall and Israel leaves after the Passover, crossing the sea on dry ground. <i>Exodus 5:1-15:21</i>
c. 1446-1445 BC <i>At Sinai</i>	● Law and tabernacle He receives the Law, breaks the tablets over the golden calf, and builds the tabernacle. <i>Exodus 19-40</i>
c. 1445 BC <i>Second year</i>	● Turned back at Kadesh Ten spies spread fear, and that generation is sentenced to wander forty years. <i>Numbers 10:11; 13:1-14:38</i>
c. 1406 BC <i>Age 120</i>	● Death on Nebo He commissions Joshua, sees the land from Mount Nebo, and dies; God buries him. <i>Deuteronomy 31-34</i>

Key activities

Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers and Deuteronomy tell Moses' story together. Deuteronomy 1–4 retells some events from Moses' own point of view.

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- I Chose God's people over Egypt.** He refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter. *Exodus 2:11–12; Hebrews 11:24–26*

 - 2 Protected the helpless.** At a desert well he defended seven sisters and watered their flock. *Exodus 2:16–17*

 - 3 Argued with God, then obeyed.** "I am slow of speech, and of a slow tongue." God answered each objection. *Exodus 3:11–4:17*

 - 4 Confronted Pharaoh.** He carried one message from God: let my people go. *Exodus 5:1–11:10*

 - 5 Led the first Passover.** Each household marked its doorposts with a lamb's blood. *Exodus 12:1–28*

 - 6 Stood firm at the sea.** "Fear ye not, stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD." *Exodus 14:13–15:18*

 - 7 Shared the load.** He appointed judges on Jethro's advice; later seventy elders helped him. *Exodus 18:13–26; Numbers 11:16–17, 24–29*

 - 8 Received the Law.** On Sinai he received the Ten Commandments and sealed the covenant with blood. *Exodus 19:1–24:8; 20:1–17*

 - 9 Stood in the gap.** After the golden calf he asked to be blotted out of God's book in Israel's place. *Exodus 32:11–14, 30–32; Psalm 106:23*

 - 10 Spoke with God as a friend.** "The LORD spake unto Moses face to face, as a man speaketh unto his friend." *Exodus 33:11, 18–23; 34:5–8*

 - 11 Struck the rock.** At Meribah he struck the rock in anger and was barred from the land. *Numbers 20:7–12*

 - 12 Handed on the work.** He laid his hands on Joshua and urged Israel to "choose life." *Numbers 27:18–23; Deuteronomy 30:19; 31:7–8*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Moses.

Old Testament

Exodus – Deuteronomy	His life from birth to death
Joshua 1:1–9	"As I was with Moses, so I will be with thee"
Psalm 90	"A Prayer of Moses the man of God"
Psalm 106:23	Moses "stood before him in the breach"
Jeremiah 15:1	Moses and Samuel as great intercessors
Malachi 4:4	"Remember ye the law of Moses my servant"

New Testament

Matthew 17:1–8	With Elijah at the transfiguration
John 1:17	Law by Moses; grace and truth by Jesus Christ
John 3:14	The serpent lifted up in the wilderness
Acts 7:20–44	Stephen retells his life
Hebrews 11:23–29	His faith praised
Tradition	Moses wrote the first five books; many think they were completed later

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Moses give for not going back to Egypt (Exodus 3:11–4:13)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God kept Moses out of the land (Numbers 20:7–12)?
3. *Apply:* Who could help carry something you are holding alone, as Jethro helped Moses?
4. *Apply:* Moses pleaded for people who let him down. Who could you pray for by name?